



TELLING TALES

According to one story, Shakespeare had to flee from Stratford after being caught poaching deer in Sir Thomas Lucy's deer park. This story comes from Shakespeare's first biography, written in 1709 by John Rowe. He based his book on tales Stratford people were telling about the playwright.

The lost years

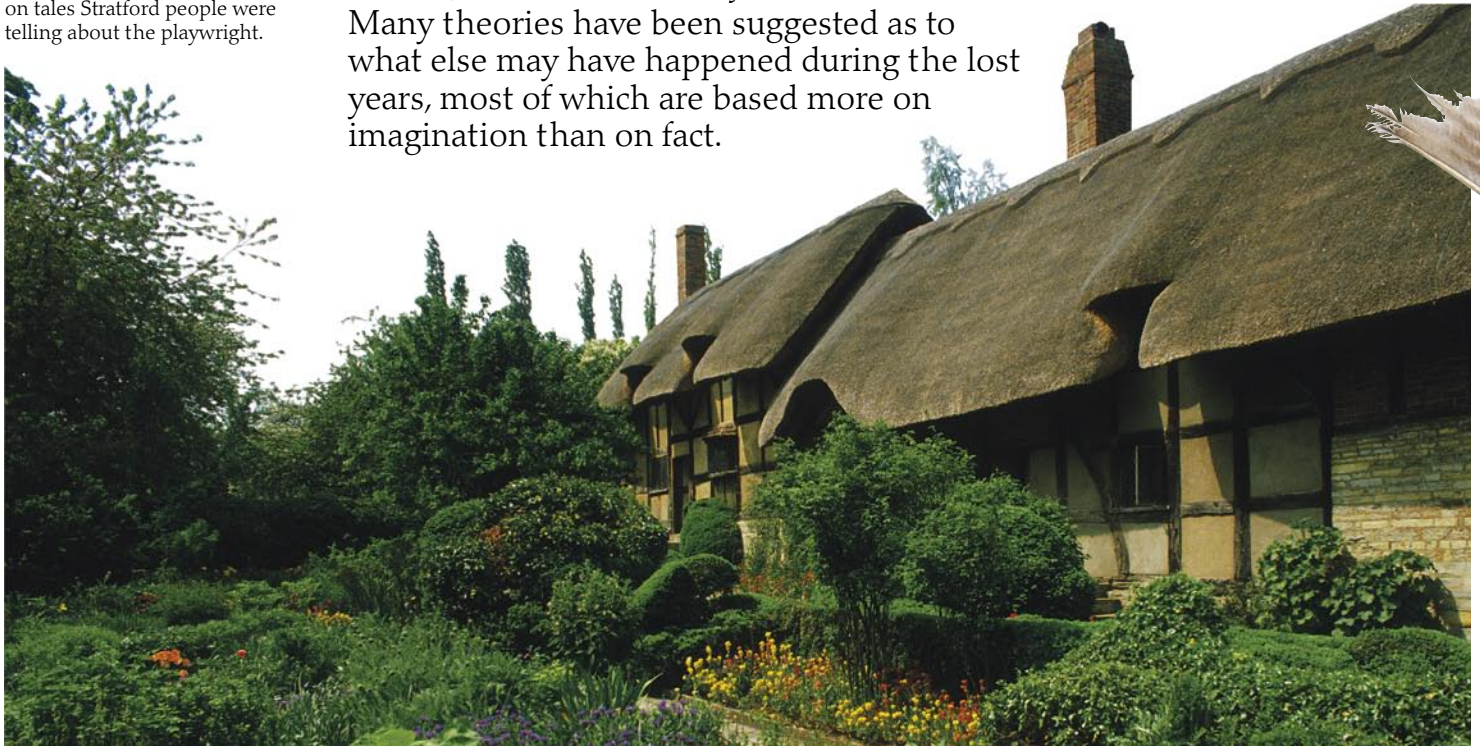
WE KNOW LITTLE of what Shakespeare did from the time he left school, at about the age of 15, until 1592, when he was described as an up-and coming playwright in London. This period is called Shakespeare's "lost years." Church records have revealed that, in November 1582, William Shakespeare married a local farmer's daughter called Anne Hathaway. He was 18, while Anne was 26 and expecting their first child, Susanna, who was born the following May. In 1585, twins arrived, who were named Judith and Hamnet. Many theories have been suggested as to what else may have happened during the lost years, most of which are based more on imagination than on fact.

Oil painting of a mother and child in christening dress, c. 1595



A PLACE IN HEAVEN

One in three babies died in the 1500s. Because unchristened babies would not go to heaven, christenings were important, and parents dressed their babies in fine clothes for the event. Susanna Shakespeare was baptized in Stratford on May 26, 1583.



HATHAWAY'S HOUSE

William's wife Anne grew up in the little village of Shottery, a mile (2 km) to the west of Stratford. Today, the house where she lived is known as Anne Hathaway's Cottage. It is not really a cottage at all, but a large farmhouse with twelve rooms.

Hunting for clues

For hundreds of years, scholars have hunted for clues that might explain what Shakespeare was doing during his lost years. Some have searched through documents written in the 1580s, looking for Shakespeare's name. Others have tried to find the answers in his plays and poems. His writing shows knowledge of types of work including medicine, soldiering, and the law, which suggests that he may have had some personal experience of them.

FATHER'S FOOTSTEPS

In Shakespeare's time, it was common for at least one son to follow his father into the family business. William may well have spent time helping John Shakespeare in his wool dealing business. The playwright later became a shrewd businessman, possibly using skills that he learned buying and selling wool.

